

EDITORIAL

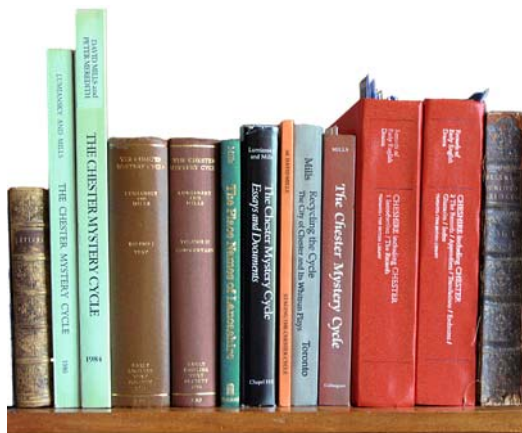
This volume of *Medieval English Theatre* and the next one comprise a collection of essays in honour of David Mills. They reflect his interest in late medieval and early modern Chester, its plays and ceremonies, and in its wider context of civic theatre and pageantry. The fact that it has ended up a two-parter is due to the number of people who wanted to write for him. Earlier versions of some of the papers were delivered at two special sessions in his honour at the Leeds International Medieval Congress in 2007. This volume includes two papers directly on Chester (Baldwin, Marshall); one on the wider world of the North West (MacLean); others comparing Chester pageants with treatments in other 'cycles' and compilations (King, Meredith, Palmer); one on civic ceremony (Twycross); and one on court celebrations (Carpenter). The next volume will contain articles by Phil Butterworth, Lawrence M. Clopper, James M. Gibson, Peter Happé, Alexandra F. Johnston, John McGavin, Elsa Strietman, and Diana Wyatt.

To the medieval-theatre world, David is Chester, ever since the late 1960s when he took on, in partnership with R.M. Lumiansky, the challenge of producing the Early English Text Society edition of the only English civic plays to have a complicated manuscript tradition. The ambition to sort out the Deimling/Matthews 1892/1916 EETS edition (has anyone yet managed to identify the enigmatic Dr Matthews?) was, he tells us, already formulated in 1964:

I remember even now how we struggled with the old Early English Text Society's editions of medieval plays, which provided virtually nothing in the way of apparatus for a beginning student. Their edition of Chester's plays was the supreme example of confusion. So, when I arrived as a young lecturer in Liverpool, and was asked what I was now going to work on, I immediately said, 'A new edition of Chester's plays'.¹

The first volume, the *Text*, came out in 1974, the second, the *Commentary*, in 1986. Since then he has been known, as Barbara Palmer says, as 'the gilded name on the EETS spine', subsequently known to an even wider audience as the name on the chestnut-coloured spine of the 1992 modern-spelling version; with collaborators, on the pale-green spines of the Leeds facsimiles of the Bodley (1973), Huntington (1980), and Harley

(1984) MSS; and on the title pages of the weighty two-volume red REED



Cheshire including Chester (2007). Together with *Essays and Documents* (1983), *Staging the Chester Cycle* (1985), *Recycling the Cycle* (1998), and *The Place Names of Lancashire* (1976), his output takes up a hefty footage on one's shelves — and that is only the books. A bibliography of his formidable body of work follows on pages 9–16.

With hindsight, the progression from edition to comprehensive coverage of the Chester Whitsun Plays in all their contexts seems a natural one. David affirms that 'From the outset, [he and Lumiansky] saw the plays as the centre of an ever-widening range of contexts. Their history was bound in with the history and culture not only of the city but of the nation'.² This wider perspective has taken in the interrelations of the manuscripts and the motives of their writers; the literary and theological sources of their unknown authors; documents bearing witness to details of performance of the Plays and of the Midsummer Show, and to the history and characters of the actors, the musicians, and the civic officials of Chester at a stirring and contentious time; and the local and wider topography of a city which as a border town confronted an often hostile Wales. To have carried this life-long project out so successfully presupposes a more than usually exploratory mind and range of skills, and, as Peter Meredith remembers from his first encounter with David in 1970 when he came from Liverpool to speak on the manuscripts of the Chester Cycle, an impressive 'ability to control such a seemingly intractable body of information'.

One gets the impression that for him it is no less than a celebration of homeland. David is very much a citizen of the North West. He remembers childhood expeditions by bus from St Helens to Chester, which became a 'very special place' for him. Educated at Prescott Grammar School, he went to Manchester University, where he duly got a First in English Language and Literature, and won undergraduate prizes, including

prophetically one from the Early English Text Society for the highest results in Part I English Language papers; then a MA thesis on Old English, and a PhD on the versification of the *Gawain* Poet (he has an Arthurian string to his bow, as well as a toponymic one). A Research Fellowship at Liverpool University led to an Assistant Lectureship and thence up the academic ladder to the Personal Chair of 1985. This is a tribute to David as *METH* knows him, so it is not the place here to go through the details of his extensive service to the university and the wider academic community: merely to point out that more than most he is rooted in the region. Sally-Beth MacLean speaks of

the quiet intensity of his commitment to his field of study, his family, and the city of Chester where he has helped bring to vivid life its historic traditions. I think of the depth of his knowledge of his home territory in the North West, not only Chester but south-west Lancashire too where he was born, educated, and has lived continuously.

As the title of one of his *METH* essays declares, 'I Know My Place'.

For him, the history of the Plays extends to the present day. Besides providing programme notes and giving public lectures on the occasion of the current revivals of Chester Plays, he has written fascinatingly about their prehistory in the twentieth century, stressing opportunities missed when innovative thinking met bureaucratic misgivings. Nugent Monck proposed 'to reproduce in Chester at Whitsuntide the whole cycle of ancient "Chester Mystery Plays"' in 1907,³ but after a trial run of three plays the previous year, the City Council got cold feet and turned down the project on grounds of cost. The Festival of Britain revival of 1951,⁴ somewhat overshadowed in subsequent reportage by E. Martin Browne's York, would have been another first. The original proposal was for six pageants on waggons in the city streets, but worries about censorship and financial returns confined them to the Cathedral refectory. His reviews for *METH* of recent Festival productions make it clear that performance is and should be a living tradition, though he is quick to point out nonsenses which run counter to the logic of the script.

He has shared this sense of place and the significance and excitement of its history with a wider local audience, in talks to schools and museums, at historical societies and literary festivals, and events connected with the Festival production of the Plays at Chester. On a more frivolous note, Elizabeth Baldwin remembers when

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David and I once gave a joint paper, where we actually outnumbered our audience (she was fortunately too polite to leave). David gave his paper with as much care and consideration as he would have to an audience of thousands, and, as our topic was the importance of marginal material, it was all rather apt.

He was one the founding fathers of METH in 1979, and has been a mainstay of its meetings and journal ever since. Olga Horner writes:

Apart from attendance at David's Inaugural Lecture at Liverpool, chance encounters with him and Joy on foreign railway stations and in motorway cafés on the way to METH conferences, and meeting him at those conferences, I know him best from his conference papers, articles, and reports on productions for METH. Even those mainly concerned with the civic drama and entertainments of Chester turn out to have universal rather than exclusively parochial applications. They demonstrate that topics such as the commercial benefits and costs of public entertainment (METH 20) and the supply and availability of music, musicians, and singers (METH 17) are common to the whole of medieval theatre. METH conferences are thematic, and when David speaks to this theme in general, his paper always turns out to be a classic: 'Characterisation in the English Mystery Cycles' (METH 5:1), 'Look at me when I'm speaking to you: The "Behold and See" Convention in Medieval Drama' (METH 7: 1) on Dialogue; 'The Now of Then' (METH 22) on Time; and 'I Know my Place' (METH 27) on Space. Typically, they start by analysing the concept and then, succinctly and comprehensibly, following a completely individual line. In his many reports on productions, David's observations can be knowledgeable, shrewd, helpful, or provocative, but never unkind; and in all his work he writes with informed authority and enviable elegance (OED: 'neatness, ingenious simplicity, and effectiveness').

As Pamela King says, 'I have never heard David give an indifferent paper, nor read anything he has written that has not been just so'.

The depth of his scholarship is matched by his unassuming self-presentation. Sally-Beth MacLean remembers how he introduced one of his most remarkable scholarly coups to the academic world:⁵

In the 1990s, David made an extraordinary discovery in North Wales, a letterbook by the noted puritan divine, Christopher

Goodman, that included some remarkable eyewitness reports, laced with moral outrage, sent to various authorities about superstitious ‘absurdities’ in the Whitsun plays he had seen performed in Chester on his return in the early 1570s. Previously David had agreed with many others that Chester’s Whitsun plays had been revised for acceptability in terms of the reformed Protestant faith but Goodman’s letters indicated that the medieval piety of the plays was maintained when the Whitsun pageant wagons rolled through the streets of Elizabethan Chester, despite what surviving texts might suggest. But did he tell anyone of this discovery? Perhaps Joy.

David waited until the first session of the International Medieval Congress at Leeds some time later when he stood up to speak to a generic topic. And then in the calmest possible style he dropped his bombshell — research that would change the fundamental understanding of the later years of the Chester Whitsun plays. I remember one of his colleagues who also had published on these ‘Protestant-reformed’ plays, asking — with a little anguish — whether the Goodman discovery just announced made a difference to his interpretation? And David simply said ‘I’ve changed my mind’.

Three of the essays in these collections (King, Johnston, Clopper) draw extensively on Christopher Goodman’s strictures on the Whitsun Plays.

We would like to thank friends and colleagues who sent us their reminiscences and appreciations of David. We have not reproduced them all in full, partly because there were so many of them, and partly because they are remarkably consistent, so we have cherry-picked a representative sample. Sarah Carpenter can sum up for us:

I do not remember when I first met David. Throughout my career in early theatre, he has always been there, first as a revered scholarly name, later as a wise and balanced presence. The papers he gives at meetings, gracefully low-key in manner, are always sharply insightful and tending to crystallise new ways of looking at material. Firmly rooted in the evidential detail from his own copious scholarship, he is always able to synthesise and present larger issues and patterns. I’ve experienced his generosity to younger colleagues, taking time to offer both quiet encouragement and scholarly support. He’s helped to establish the friendly, supportive character of the scholarly community that’s characterised the last 30 years of the subject.

We would also like to thank Joy for stealing David's CV for us. This is about him; but it would not be complete without a tribute to her. As Elsa Strietman points out, it is impossible to come up with a recollection of David that does not involve Joy as well. Very much her own woman, but very much part of the package: as Elsa also says, 'two for the price of one'.

What all this does not mention is his sense of humour: what Sally-Beth MacLean calls his 'endearing mischief'. So to redress the balance, Barbara Palmer offers her recollection of her first meeting with this *eminence grise*: 'In 1988, I was formally introduced to David, who at the time was wearing an academic gown and aluminium pie-tin "hat" as a prophet in N.Town Pageant 7 at the University of Toronto'. We are sorry that we have no photograph of this occasion. However, as a footnote, we can reproduce a *trouaille* from the Prescott Grammar School website,⁶ showing one A.D. Mills as Tom Twist in the 1955 school play, *She Stoops to Conquer*. It makes a nice foil to the academically serious lecturer of our frontispiece.



So, David, with respect and affection, we ask you to accept this first bouquet of mixed flowers. The second will follow in short order. As Elizabeth Baldwin says, 'Here's to you, then, David, both scholar and gentleman extraordinaire'.

NOTES

1. *Recycling the Cycle: The City of Chester and its Whitsun Plays* (University of Toronto Press, 1998) vii.
2. *Recycling the Cycle* viii.
3. 'Reviving the Chester Plays' *METH* 13 (1991) 39–51.
4. 'The 1951 and 1952 Revivals of the Chester Plays' *METH* 15 (1993) 111–123.
5. See *REED: Cheshire including Chester* (Toronto UP, 2007) cxxxvi–cxxxvii, 168–170, 143–8, and 202–3; *Recycling the Cycle* 146–51, 179–82, 221–2.
6. <<http://www.prescotian.info/stoopsconquer.htm>>.

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